

Garrett Thompson

CYBE 2340

Professor Franklin

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A Review of Flock Cameras

In April of 2026, an ex-Costa Mesa, California, police officer, Robert Jossett, was accused of using Flock cameras to track individuals he had previously had romantic relations with. He used the power of his profession to track his wife, his ex-romantic partner, and her new boyfriend [1]. The Flock cameras he accessed are part of a nationwide network of License Plate Readers (LPRs), which are commonly used by police to track criminals, locate kidnapped children, and find lost elders [2]. However, these cameras are raising privacy concerns, as events such as those in California have left citizens questioning their privacy in their own neighborhoods. The cameras generate a unique identifier for each detected vehicle, consisting of the license plate, make, model, and color. While Flock Safety markets its technology as a tool for public safety, the lack of standardized oversight and the aggregation of massive datasets create significant risks to privacy and freedom of expression, effectively turning the movement of individuals every day into readily available data.

Flock cameras are located in all 50 states, totaling over 40,000, and are commonly mounted on light or power poles, scanning every license plate as someone drives by. Positioned along campus entry roads, highways, and main boulevards, no traffic goes unseen in participating communities. The data from these cameras is optionally shared in a nationwide network of law enforcement agencies [3]. This network allows law enforcement agencies from across the country to access cameras and data. This is what allows law enforcement to track interstate criminals, but would also allow a beligerant user to discover that you are out of state. Flock boasts a strict auditing system to monitor who accesses records and when; however, it is imperfect. It does not require a search warrant, meaning that compliance with the 4th amendment is not verified. Following an investigation into search audits, the main reasons for accessing a record in the Flock system were inherently vague, such as “suspect” or “investigation” [4]. This lack of responsibility within the system is driving privacy concerns in individuals nationwide.

Many people believe that the use of large-scale camera networks such as this is unethical. This is comparable to our class discussion about camera monitoring on school laptops that are being taken home. Even if the tool is not intended for negative uses, it raises privacy concerns because it could be used for illegal or unfounded purposes [5]. If this is applied to the Ethical OS model, it clearly violates two risk zones, Surveillance State and Data Control & Monetization. Flock cameras contribute heavily to the ever-growing surveillance state in the United States. This is a straightforward example, as the government can easily track your movement in participating communities. The data collected could show someone visiting a perfectly legal location that may have social consequences if the footage were to fall into the wrong hands. However, this is the entire idea behind the system, providing a network to locate citizens, rather than being an accidental effect of a program. Data Control & Monetization is also highly concerning risk zone in this operation. Most people do not realize that Flock owns several of its own cameras across the country, meaning they are making money off your information without your consent or informing you. This is done by providing your information to law enforcement agencies via a paid service: access to the Flock network. However, more broadly, citizens are concerned about the data collected. Individuals have no way to find out whether they are being searched, or when or where they have been tracked. Flock has attempted to improve this situation by instituting a default data-expiry date of 30 days after collection; agencies can choose to extend this time as long as they would like, up to indefinitely storing information. Additionally, reasons for accessing information must be documented to document any potentially illegal access [2]. However, this process does not benefit the public in any way; requiring any entry does not mandate truthfulness or require judicial approval to ensure that a citizen's rights are not being violated. For example, when reviewing a log of searches from the Ankeny Police Department, 311 searches in the last 30 days are all entered as "INVESTIGATION" [6]. This is no better than requiring no reason at all, as searches aren't tied to a specific investigation or search warrant, and with no distinction, auditing these for potential wrongdoing would require a binary search of every record. Flock offers the option to provide this information, regardless of its value to the public, through a transparency portal; many agencies refuse to release it due to confidentiality concerns. This is an attempt by Flock to improve transparency; it has utterly failed in the public's eyes.

Beyond its current use, it is important to consider potential uses. If a governmental body wanted to investigate or catalog individuals who attended a protest, simply exercising their freedom of expression, this system would allow them to do so. As noted in the Ankeny Police Department public search log, many searches return results from only one camera, even though no time period is specified [6]. The network would allow them to discover

every vehicle that traveled through the area for any period of time they wish, without generating any additional suspicion. This threat could lead to blanket censorship—citizens limiting their free speech due to fear of retaliation. This would be detrimental to the founding principles of our country.

Products that offer both significant benefits and privacy or security risks often lead the public to desire boundaries on their use. Flock cameras, for example, can enhance public safety by tracking dangerous criminals or finding lost individuals. However, many citizens maintain concerns about potential misuse, such as unwarranted surveillance and data breaches, which can outweigh these advantages. In today's heightened surveillance culture, where data collection on everyday individuals is increasingly common, skepticism and distrust grow ever more. Instances of misuse and poor management of surveillance data contribute to the public's resistance to technologies like Flock cameras. With the number of cameras only increasing every year, this is not a problem likely to disappear soon.

Sources

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